Chapter0

"I shall be the shield of the helpless, the sword against cruelty, and the light that guides those lost in darkness.

I shall not abandon those who cry for aid, nor turn away from those who stand beneath the shadow of death.

I shall defend the innocent, regardless of their blood, their faith, or the name by which they are called.

I shall raise my blade not for glory, nor for vengeance, but for those who cannot raise their own.

And should the day come when my strength fails, when my armor breaks, and when my final breath escapes my lips, I shall stand firm until my body becomes the last wall between the innocent and their destruction.

For I am a Paladin.

My life is my vow. My strength is their protection. And my death shall never be the price of another's surrender."

These were the words every Paladin swore before the altar, beneath the watchful eyes of the gods and the witnesses who had gathered to see a new guardian rise.

Yet, in a world that praised strength above all else, few truly understood what those words demanded.

The world was divided among three peoples.

Humans ruled the sunlit lands, building stone castles and bustling towns beneath the banners of kings. They forged iron into swords, raised armies in the name of their lords, and passed down stories of monstrous creatures lurking beneath the earth. Among those creatures, none were feared more than the Orcs.

Red-skinned and horned, the Orcs dwelled within vast underground caverns, carving their homes into the natural architecture of the stone itself. Their settlements were unlike anything found on the surface, shaped by ancient tunnels, towering stalagmites, subterranean rivers, and enormous chambers illuminated by strange glowing minerals. Their society had its own customs, traditions, and laws, yet the humans knew little of them.

To most humans, an Orc was a demon.

And demons, they believed, existed only to be slain.

But the truth was far more complicated.

Orcs were no more inherently cruel than humans. Their horns were a natural part of their biology: males developed theirs as they matured, while females grew horns only during pregnancy. Their red skin and unusual appearance had earned them fear and hatred, but neither their blood nor their birthplace determined the kind of people they would become.

Beyond the territories claimed by humans and the hidden realms of the Orcs lived the Elves.

Few had ever seen an Elf, and fewer still could claim to understand them. They were an elusive people who guarded the world's most precious resource: the very heart of magic, a mysterious substance that made both sorcery and extraordinary technology possible. Without it, the greatest enchantments would crumble, and the most advanced inventions would become nothing more than lifeless metal.

The Elves alone possessed the knowledge and means to command this power.

And so, while humans and Orcs struggled against one another in fear and ignorance, the true secrets of their world remained hidden.

It was into this divided world that a certain soldier was born.

He was not a hero. He possessed neither extraordinary strength nor remarkable skill with a blade. His fellow soldiers knew him as a nervous man, one who hesitated when the horns of war sounded and whose hands trembled whenever battle drew near.

Some called him a coward.

He had never denied it.

During a clash between human soldiers and an Orc warband, his company was ordered to defend a small village near the border. The battle quickly descended into chaos. Steel rang against steel, arrows darkened the air, and the screams of the wounded mingled with the cries of terrified villagers.

The human soldiers began to retreat.

Amid the confusion, the young soldier found himself separated from his comrades. His sword felt impossibly heavy in his hand. His legs begged him to run, and every instinct told him that staying would mean certain death.

Then he heard a child screaming.

Through the smoke, he saw a group of villagers trapped beneath a collapsed wooden structure. An Orc warrior stood nearby, its shadow stretching across the frightened figures as another building burned behind it.

The soldier froze.

He knew what the stories said about Orcs. He knew what his commanders had taught him. He knew that no one would blame him for fleeing a battle that was already lost.

Nobody would even know if he ran.

But the child screamed again.

And the soldier moved.

He charged forward with a trembling hand wrapped around his sword, placing himself between the villagers and the approaching warrior. He was terrified. He was certain that he would die. Yet, when the Orc raised its weapon, he did not step aside.

He could not defeat an enemy he had been taught to fear all his life.

He could barely stand his ground.

But he could refuse to let the people behind him die alone.

And that, as it happened, was enough to change his life forever.

From the edge of the ruined village, a Paladin watched the young soldier make his stand.

The knight had seen warriors fight for gold, kings fight for territory, and men throw away their lives for the empty promise of glory.

But he had rarely seen a frightened man choose to remain afraid—and stand his ground anyway.

When the battle ended, the Paladin approached the soldier.

"You were afraid," the knight observed.

The young man lowered his eyes. "Yes."

"You knew you might die."

"Yes."

"And yet you stood between them and the blade."

The soldier looked back at the villagers he had saved. His hands were still shaking.

"I couldn't let them die."

For a long moment, the Paladin said nothing.

Then he extended a hand.

"Tell me, soldier. Have you ever considered becoming a Paladin?"

The young man stared at him in disbelief.

He had never been the bravest soldier. He had never been the strongest, the wisest, or the most worthy.

He had only been afraid.

And yet, for the first time in his life, someone had looked at him and seen something other than a coward.

The Paladin smiled beneath his helm.

"Come. There is an oath you must learn."

And so began the journey of a man who had never believed himself worthy of becoming a hero——and a world that would soon learn what it truly meant to protect the innocent.